A Rising Tide

INDIAN WOMEN ARE BEGINNING TO SEIZE CONTROL OF THEIR FINANCIAL DESTINY TO EXPLORE OPTIONS OUTSIDE GOLD AND BANK DEPOSITS AND INVEST IN THE MARKETS INSTEAD

By **JUMANA SHAH & SONAL KHETARPAL**

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS / AI**

Till March 2024, Mumbai-based business development professional Aswasana Mishra was content to lock away all her money in bank fixed deposits. Then, the 54-year-old discovered LXME. The women's-only investment app was running an online challenge to save Rs 50,000 in four months, and, before she knew it, Aswasana had embarked on her investment journey.

"It got me to save small amounts under Rs 500 and invest daily," she says. Twenty-one challenges later, she has built a diversified portfolio—52 per cent in equity, 30 per cent in gold funds, the rest in debt and hybrid instruments. The returns beat her old FDs. But what investing has taught her is goal-setting discipline and granted her a sense of financial autonomy. Last year, she travelled to the Maldives with her investment gains; this year, it was the Andamans. "I'm not asking my husband for any money. I'm using my own savings to fund my trips," she says. Now, she is urging her 18-year-old daughter to do the same.

Aswasana represents the new wave of financially aware women who are not afraid to take charge of their investment journey. The numbers tell the story. The periodic Market Pulse data by the National Stock Exchange (NSE) in January 2026 recorded 31 million women investors in December 2025, 24.8 per cent of NSE's 125 million investor base, up from 24.1 per cent in 2024 and 22.8 per cent in 2023. Nearly 50 per cent of India's states now have female investor shares above the national average, compared to just 44 per cent in FY23. While Maharashtra (92.8 per cent), Tamil Nadu (28.4 per cent), Gujarat (28.2 per cent) and Telangana (25.4 per cent) lead the trend, smaller states such as Mizoram (32.4 per cent), Sikkim (31.2 per cent) and Goa (30.6 per cent), as well as Union Territories like Chandigarh (32.3 per cent) and Delhi (30.5 per cent), now rank among the highest in terms of female participation.

That financial awareness among women has spread beyond the metros is something a 2025 report by PhonePe Wealth, the investment and broking arm of the PhonePe ecosystem, also discovered, after analysing the 100,000 women investors on its platform in 2024. Approximately 72 per cent of the women investors came from cities like Varanasi, Ranchi, Dehradun, Guwahati and Vadodara.

When Zerodha co-founder Nithin Kamath found that women accounted for 31.39 per cent of their total investor base in August 2025, up from 11.12 per cent in January 2019, "I was surprised and wanted to understand what had changed," he says. Renu Maheshwari, chairperson of the Association of Registered Investment Advisers in India (ARIA), attempts to demystify the trend. "A silent revolution is unfolding in India," she says. More women are entering the workforce: the female labour force participa-